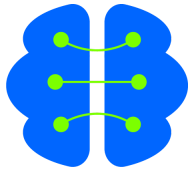


TRAVERSE THINK TANK

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Government Documents in the Dark

The Case for Open Data Infrastructure in East Africa

Focus Countries: Uganda · Rwanda · Kenya

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Built for Africa · Driven by Evidence

Executive Summary

Across East Africa, billions in public funds flow through government procurement processes each year. Yet the overwhelming majority of citizens, journalists, and civil society actors cannot access a complete, machine-readable record of a single public contract. The documents exist. The problem is that they are locked inside fragmented portals, guarded by login walls, and published in formats that resist analysis.

This white paper examines Uganda's Electronic Government Procurement (eGP) system, its design, its achievements, and the structural gaps that continue to shield procurement data from meaningful public scrutiny. It benchmarks Uganda's trajectory against Rwanda's Umucyo platform and Kenya's Public Procurement Information Portal (PPIP). And it sets out the role that open data infrastructure including AI-powered document aggregation platforms can play in closing the transparency deficit.

But this paper does not treat transparency merely as a technical or administrative challenge. Grounded in original editorial analysis, it examines a more uncomfortable question: whether the opacity of government documents is, in part, intentional and whether the tools we are building to navigate that opacity are themselves sharpening or blunting the public's capacity for independent thought.

Key Findings

Uganda's eGP system is live but narrow, covering only 36 of a target 420 government entities as of early 2025, with a mandatory login requirement that functionally excludes the public. Rwanda's Umucyo system is the continental benchmark, publishing OCDS-formatted data via open portal and API. Kenya has the legal architecture but persistent implementation gaps. Across all three countries, AI-powered civic-tech has significant headroom to convert opaque procurement archives into actionable public intelligence provided that technology is used to sharpen civic scrutiny rather than replace it.

1. The Complexity of Government and the Right to Understand It

Government is among the most complex institutions human civilisation has ever constructed. It is a maze of bureaucratic procedures, legal obligations, interagency dependencies, and competing political mandates. It carries the weight of solving collective problems i.e infrastructure, health, security, education at a scale that no private actor can replicate. And it does so, in democratic theory at least, in service of the people who fund it.

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If this growing institution is genuinely in the interest of the people, then the people should have more visibility into what its different institutions are working on. The majority of those who benefit from government services remain largely ignorant about how government actually works not because they lack the intelligence to understand it, but because access to the information that would enable that understanding has, in many cases, never been made available to them.

This is not accidental. Research on government information asymmetry the structural gap between what governments know about their own activities and what citizens can access consistently finds that opacity is not merely a by-product of complexity. It is, in many instances, a feature rather than a bug.

A 2019 systematic literature review in Public Performance and Management Review, examining 73 papers on open government data, found that information asymmetry between government and the public is structurally embedded: those involved in government processes will generally possess substantially more information about their activities than the public, and that this asymmetry is compounded by opacity in how that information is managed and released.

1.1 Propaganda and the Managed Release of Truth

The deliberate management of public information has a long institutional history. The term propaganda from the Latin congregatio de propaganda fide, a committee tasked with spreading religious doctrine entered secular governance as a tool for shaping public perception of complex or uncomfortable realities. In modern democratic theory, the tension between what governments know and what they choose to tell citizens is framed as a problem of accountability; in practice, it has often been managed as a problem of communication strategy.

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There is a growing tendency within top leadership across different governments to shelter the citizens from certain truths under the defence that the population cannot stomach them. But the question we must ask is this: if we do not operate with truth as the foundation, then which solutions are we building? And who are we building them for?

Legal scholar Caroline Mala Corbin, writing in the Ohio State Law Journal, defines government propaganda as the deliberate dissemination of false or misleading claims on matters of public interest, noting that such communications disrupt democratic self-governance by muddying the public information environment and making it harder for citizens to make decisions grounded in accurate facts. The harm, Corbin argues, is not merely informational, it is structural: when citizens cannot trust official communications, the entire epistemic foundation of democratic accountability is weakened.

Annual Reviews of Political Science research on information politics in authoritarian and semi-authoritarian settings has documented how governments invest in what researchers call 'managed information environments' releasing enough information to signal responsiveness while withholding the specific data that would enable citizens to verify claims, detect failures, or identify beneficiaries of public resources.

In the procurement context, this manifests not as outright falsehood but as strategic incompleteness: tender notices are published, but evaluation criteria are not. Contract awards are announced, but pricing is withheld. Projects are declared complete, but performance data is never disclosed. Each individual omission is defensible; collectively, they constitute a managed opacity that benefits those who operate within the system over those the system is supposed to serve.

2. Documents, Power, and the Art of Manipulation

The government runs on documentation. Every policy decision, every procurement award, every budget allocation, every regulatory determination leaves a documentary trail. Whoever controls that trail controls the record of what happened, when, and why. This is not a peripheral observation; it is foundational to understanding why procurement fraud and corruption in the public sector are so persistent, and so difficult to prosecute.

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Any person who has laboured in government long enough knows that documents run the government. And any man or woman who has mastered the art of documentation is able to manipulate, change, and commit fraud freely because many people cannot read the documents, and even fewer know what to look for when they do.

A 2024 paper published in the Emerald Publishing Records Management Journal examined the relationship between procurement records and accountability, finding that manipulation of solicitation documents is among the most common and least detected forms of procurement fraud. In competitive procurement processes, records fraud typically involves the strategic omission of key documents and bid evaluation matrices, conflict of interest declarations, or communication records between procurement officers and preferred vendors that would otherwise create an auditable evidence trail. The paper notes that direct contracting processes, which lack competition, are inherently more vulnerable: with no competing bids to compare against, the manipulation of a single document set is sufficient to direct a contract.

Research published in the African Journal of Public Affairs identified document manipulation as one of the most frequently encountered corruption methods in African public procurement, alongside fraud, bribery, collusion, and extortion. The paper applied OECD risk indicators to procurement processes, identifying that corruption risks are highest precisely at the points in the procurement lifecycle where documentary evidence is most concentrated: bid opening, evaluation, and contract award.

2.1 The Document Literacy Gap

The power of documentation as a tool of manipulation rests substantially on a structural asymmetry in literacy not literacy in the basic sense, but what researchers call document literacy: the capacity to read, interpret, and critically evaluate complex formal documents including contracts, regulatory instruments, evaluation reports, and audit findings.

In East African contexts, this gap is acute. Citizens who interact with the government primarily through service delivery hospitals, roads, schools rarely encounter the procurement documents

that determine how those services are funded and contracted. Even where documents are nominally public, the combination of legal language, technical procurement terminology, and institutional jargon creates an effective access barrier that limits meaningful engagement to a small professional class.

This is the environment in which procurement fraud thrives. As noted in the Journal of Transport and Supply Chain Management research on South African public procurement corruption, the reason that corruption persists even in the face of legal frameworks designed to prevent it is not the absence of rules it is the absence of citizens, journalists, and civil society actors who can read, interpret, and contest the documentary evidence of wrongdoing. Without that external scrutiny function, the internal accountability mechanisms of government institutions are rarely sufficient.

3. Uganda: The eGP System Under Review

3.1 Legal and Institutional Framework

Uganda's public procurement is governed primarily by the Public Procurement and Disposal of Public Assets (PPDA) Act of 2003, subsequently amended in 2011 and 2021. The PPDA Authority serves as the principal regulatory body, overseeing procurement across central government ministries, departments, and agencies (MDAs), as well as local government entities. Under Article 224(3) and 225(3) of the relevant provisions, procuring entities are required to publish notifications of evaluated bidders and contract awards establishing the foundational disclosure obligation.

The PPDA Regulations 2023 updated procedural requirements following the 2021 amendment. The Buy Uganda Build Uganda (BUBU) policy, enacted in 2014, adds a preference and reservation layer for domestically produced goods and services.

3.2 The Electronic Government Procurement (eGP) System

Developed by PPDA and technically supported by NITA-U, the eGP system was designed to address the inefficiencies and corruption risks of Uganda's paper-based procurement process. Funded under the World Bank's Regional Communications Infrastructure Programme (RCIP), it was piloted across eleven entities in July 2021. The system covers the comprehensive procurement lifecycle: planning, bidding, evaluation, contract award, and invoicing, with a supplier portal for registered vendors.

eGP Rollout Status (April 2025)

As of April 2025, the eGP system has been deployed in 25 institutions and 36 entities are actively enrolled, against a target of 420 government entities by the end of the 2024/2025 fiscal year. At current pace, Uganda remains materially behind its own deployment targets.

3.3 The Access Problem: Login-Gated Transparency

The eGP Uganda portal (egpuganda.go.ug) requires user registration and login to access procurement data. This single design decision has profound transparency implications. A citizen, journalist, or researcher seeking to audit a government contract must first create an account a barrier that inverts the transparency obligation, placing the burden on citizens to request access to information that should be their default right.

This stands in direct contrast to the principle underlying open contracting frameworks: that procurement data should be proactively disclosed, freely accessible, and structured for analysis

without institutional friction. As established in Public Administration Review research, transparency as disclosure where the state proactively releases information rather than waiting for citizens to request it is the higher standard, and the standard that most directly enables accountability.

3.4 Structural Implementation Challenges

Research published in the International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science (June 2024) identified three challenge categories:

- **Technological:** Inadequate IT and networking infrastructure, particularly outside the capital, limiting participation by smaller procuring entities and regional suppliers.
- **Organisational:** Resistance to change and insufficient training among procurement officers, combined with acceptance challenges among suppliers unfamiliar with digital tendering.
- **Contextual:** Legal framework gaps and the absence of formal open contracting policies mandating structured data publication aligned to international standards.

A further problem identified in a March 2025 PPDA stakeholder engagement was double data submission entities required to report into both the eGP system and the older Government Procurement Portal (GPP), creating redundancy, data inconsistencies, and compliance fatigue among procurement officers.

3.5 What the eGP System Does Not Publish

Even within onboarded entities, the system's public-facing transparency is constrained. The following are either absent or available only to registered users:

- Detailed bidder participation data who tendered, at what price, against which specification
- Evaluation score sheets and justifications for award decisions
- Contract performance data: delivery timelines, milestone payments, variations, and completion status
- Beneficial ownership information for awarded vendors
- Debarment and blacklist records for non-performing contractors

Uganda's eGP system currently digitises the process of procurement without opening the intelligence of procurement. The former is an administrative achievement; the latter is the accountability dividend.

4. Benchmarks: Rwanda and Kenya

4.1 Rwanda: Umucyo — The Continental Gold Standard

System Architecture

Rwanda's Umucyo meaning 'transparency' in Kinyarwanda is recognised as the most advanced e-government procurement system in Africa. The World Bank has confirmed that Rwanda is the first country on the continent to roll out an end-to-end e-procurement solution across the country and for all procurement categories. Modelled on South Korea's KONEPS platform, Umucyo is used by all national and local government agencies for almost all procurement procedures, with a clear political mandate to make all government business electronic by 2025.

The Open Contracting Portal

In November 2024, Rwanda launched a new open contracting portal supported by the Open Contracting Partnership and the UK's FCDO. The portal publishes machine-readable data in the Open Contracting Data Standard (OCDS) format, allowing users to trace procedures across the planning, tender, award, and contracting stages. Data is downloadable in spreadsheet formats and accessible via API with no registration or login requirement. The portal covers all central and local government agencies, with all procurement above 3,000,000 RWF included.

Rwanda's Transparency Score

A 2024 ScienceDirect study measuring procurement transparency globally awarded Rwanda a score of 0.748 among the highest in sub-Saharan Africa, ahead of several middle-income countries in Latin America and the Middle East.

Remaining Gaps

Despite its advances, a December 2024 Transparency International Rwanda report found that while 71 percent of respondents viewed Rwanda's procurement as transparent, only 8.55 percent reported having actual public access to procurement data, a sharp gap between perception and practice. Barriers cited included corruption, inadequate digital infrastructure at the local level, and restricted information access.

4.2 Kenya: Legal Architecture, Implementation Gaps

Kenya's procurement transparency framework is among the most legally robust in East Africa. Presidential Executive Order No. 2 of 2018 mandated publication of all public contracting information. The PPRA launched the Public Procurement Information Portal (PIIP) in 2018. The Companies (Amendment) Act of 2017 requires beneficial ownership reporting. Kenya's

successive OGP National Action Plans have deepened the commitment to OCDS implementation.

However, Kenya's own OGP reviewers note that full OCDS-compliant data publication remains unachieved. A new end-to-end e-GP system with a public portal publishing all procurement data in OCDS, CSV, and PDF formats is under active development in 2025. Commitments to a debarment register and formal whistleblower protections remain in progress.

4.3 Comparative Scorecard

Indicator	Uganda (eGP)	Rwanda (Umucyo)	Kenya (PPIP/eGP)
System Coverage	36 of 420 entities	All national & local agencies	Partial new system in rollout
Public Access (No Login)	No registration required	Yes open portal & API	Partial PPIP public, limited
OCDS Compliance	Not adopted	Fully adopted (Nov 2024)	Committed, not yet achieved
Machine-readable API	Not publicly available	Available, full access	Under development
Contract Performance Data	Not published	Full lifecycle published	Partial
Debarment Registry	Not public	Under development	Committed, in progress
Beneficial Ownership	Not linked	Not fully linked	Legal basis; partial
OGP Signatory	Yes	Yes	Yes

5. Technology, Transparency, and the Paradox of AI

Technology is the most powerful instrument available for closing the transparency gap in East African public procurement. AI-powered aggregation platforms, open data standards, automated anomaly detection, and citizen-facing dashboards can collectively convert opaque documentary archives into accessible public intelligence. The evidence from Rwanda's Umucyo and Ukraine's ProZorro demonstrates that this is not theoretical.

However, technology carries a paradox that this white paper cannot ignore, one that bears directly on the question of whether open data infrastructure, however well-designed, can deliver the accountability dividends it promises.

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Artificial intelligence has transformed research, analysis, and access to information in ways that were unimaginable a generation ago. That is not in dispute. What is less comfortable to acknowledge is that these same tools have measurably eroded the critical thinking capacity of their heaviest users not through any design flaw, but through the simple logic of convenience: when thinking is optional, many people opt out. For any accountability system that ultimately depends on an engaged, curious public, this is a problem worth naming.

5.1 The Cognitive Offloading Problem

Research published in the peer-reviewed journal *Societies* (Gerlich, 2025), drawing on surveys and interviews with 666 participants across multiple age groups and educational backgrounds, found a statistically significant negative correlation ($r = -0.68$, $p < 0.001$) between frequent AI tool usage and critical thinking scores. The mediating mechanism identified was cognitive offloading, the tendency to delegate reasoning and analysis tasks to AI systems, reducing the cognitive exercise required to develop independent judgment.

A separate 2024 systematic review on the negative effects of digital technology on cognition confirmed that unstructured or excessive reliance on AI systems shifts effort from analysis and evaluation to acceptance of AI outputs, with reported gains clustering at lower cognitive levels while higher-order reasoning weakens under automation bias and reduced metacognitive effort.

For procurement transparency, this creates a specific risk. Open data platforms that make it easy to retrieve summaries, flag anomalies, and generate alerts may reduce the incentive for citizens, journalists, and civil society actors to engage deeply with the underlying documents. The tool answers the question before the question has been fully formed. The curiosity that drives investigation is pre-empted by the convenience that delivers conclusions.

This is not an argument against AI-powered transparency tools. It is an argument for designing them in ways that support rather than supplant human analytical capacity. The tools that will most effectively serve accountability are those that direct users toward evidence, contextualise anomalies within systemic patterns, and prompt questions rather than delivering pre-packaged answers.

5.2 Five Technology Interventions

1. Open Data Standards Adoption (OCDS)

Adopting the Open Contracting Data Standard is the single highest-leverage transparency improvement available to Uganda. It would require PPDA and NITA-U to restructure eGP's data publication layer to output OCDS-compliant JSON, remove the login barrier, and commit to full-lifecycle data publication. Rwanda's adoption in November 2024 provides a directly applicable regional model.

2. AI-Powered Document Aggregation

Even where data is published, it remains scattered across hundreds of entity portals, buried in PDFs, and inaccessible to anyone who does not know precisely where to look. AI-powered platforms such as Public Record EA developed by Traverse Minds address this by crawling, indexing, and structuring government documents from multiple sources into a single searchable interface. Applied to procurement data, such platforms can extract structured fields from unstructured PDFs (contracting entity, vendor, contract value, award date), surface single-bidder contracts and recurrent award patterns, and provide alert systems for journalists and civil society.

3. Beneficial Ownership Transparency Integration

Beneficial ownership integration linking national company registries with procurement award data through unique identifier matching enables detection of conflicts of interest between procurement officers and vendor shareholders. Uganda's URSB, Kenya's BRS, and Rwanda's RDB all maintain company registration data. The technical challenge is linkage; the political challenge is will. Several countries including Ukraine and Slovakia have made beneficial ownership transparency a core component of their e-procurement infrastructure.

4. Automated Red Flag Detection

Machine learning tools trained on procurement datasets can identify statistical anomalies associated with corrupt practices: contract values consistently just below competitive tendering thresholds (bid splitting); contracts awarded to recently registered vendors; unusually short tender windows that exclude competition; repeated awards to the same supplier across different entities. Colombia's SECOP II and Ukraine's ProZorro have demonstrated that publicly

accessible automated red flag analytics materially increases the cost of corrupt practices by improving detection probability.

5. Mobile-First Citizen Dashboards

For transparency to produce accountability, data must be usable by ordinary citizens not just technically capable researchers. Mobile-first citizen dashboards that translate procurement data into plain-language summaries, map contract locations to communities, and allow service delivery feedback are essential in East African contexts where smartphone penetration significantly outpaces desktop internet access.

6. Policy Recommendations

For the Government of Uganda (PPDA / NITA-U)

1. Remove the login requirement from egpuganda.go.ug and make all procurement notices, award data, and contract documents publicly accessible without registration.
2. Adopt the Open Contracting Data Standard (OCDS) as the mandatory publication format for all eGP data, with a clear implementation timeline tied to the ongoing entity onboarding rollout.
3. Mandate publication of contract performance data including delivery status, payment milestones, and contract variations as a condition of final payment authorisation for contracts above UGX 50 million.
4. Commission an independent civic-tech audit of the eGP system's transparency architecture, with findings published and remediation tracked publicly.

For Development Partners (World Bank, USAID, FCDO)

1. Condition eGP technical assistance and funding on measurable transparency milestones: OCDS adoption, public access without authentication, contract performance disclosure rather than entity onboarding numbers alone.
2. Fund regional OCDS capacity-building for procurement officers and civil society actors, building on Rwanda's experience and the Open Contracting Partnership's Africa engagement model.

For Civic-Tech Actors and Researchers

1. Invest in AI-powered procurement data aggregation platforms that can work with imperfect, non-OCDS data scraping and structuring procurement intelligence from existing PDFs while better standards are adopted.
2. Design transparency tools that enhance rather than replace human analytical capacity: directing users toward evidence and prompting questions, rather than delivering pre-packaged summaries.
3. Establish a regional procurement monitoring coalition across Uganda, Kenya, and Rwanda to conduct systematic cross-border analysis and share methodologies.

7. Conclusion

Uganda has invested meaningfully in digitising government procurement. The eGP system is live and technically capable. But digitisation is not transparency, and transparency is not accountability. The full chain from open data to informed citizens to contested decisions to improved outcomes requires every link to hold.

Rwanda's Umucyo platform demonstrates that an African country can close the gap: publishing machine-readable, OCDS-compliant procurement data accessible to any citizen without authentication, across the full contracting lifecycle. The distance between Uganda's current architecture and Rwanda's is not primarily technical. It is a policy distance, a question of institutional will.

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There is a question underneath all the technical arguments in this paper, and it deserves to be stated plainly: if the governments we are trying to hold accountable have never fully operated on truth, and the citizens we are trying to empower have been given tools that think for them, what precisely, are we building? Open data is the right answer to the wrong version of the problem. The full version requires something harder: a public that wants to know, knows how to find out, and cannot be pacified with a dashboard.

The transparency deficit in East African procurement is both a governance challenge and a civic opportunity. Open data infrastructure, AI-powered analysis, and mobile-accessible dashboards are powerful tools. But their ultimate value depends on citizens, journalists, and civil society actors who are willing to ask the uncomfortable questions that well-designed documents are meant to prevent anyone from asking.

Government documents should not be in the dark. The infrastructure to bring them into the light exists. The task now is to build the political consensus, the institutional mandates, the civic-tech tools and the human curiosity to make that transition irreversible.

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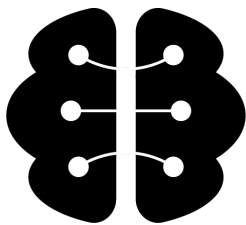
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